

伪像报告

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Simulacrum Reports

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Synopsis:

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Among the entire human population, only a rare 1% are born with an innate "gateway" — the ability to enter strange and unpredictable otherworlds teeming with peril and possibility.

For dreams, for wealth, for freedom... for a life lived with fierce, blazing intensity — among that 1%, brave souls have never been in short supply.

But what if you only discover it when you are already old and fading?

What if you know full well that it exists, yet are simply born unable to enter?

What if you have already been swallowed by it once?

In the world of this novel, the exchange rate for the currency Black Moore (黑摩尔) against RMB is 1:8.

Whenever a monetary figure appears, multiply it by 8 to get the RMB equivalent.

--This is an ensemble cast story. Hope you enjoy it.

--My completed works 《末日乐园》 and 《野鹿便利店》 are available to read.

*****This story is not a conventional web novel, and certainly not a power-fantasy wish-fulfillment read — please proceed with care.*****

Chapter 1 — Mai Minghe: I Want to Pick More Daisies

When Mai Minghe woke, the room was dark, and what filtered in beneath the curtains was still the dead of night.

She had always been a light sleeper, waking several times each night — but tonight the reason was different. A small, hard sound had reached her through the steady hush of the room, "whooo — whooo," and pulled her out of sleep.

What was making that noise?

Her mind was thick with drowsiness, and for a moment she couldn't quite work out what was happening.

Metal scraped and clinked against metal, and then — crack — the lock gave, the cylinder jumped, and the door swung open with a long, drawn-out creak. The hinges hadn't been oiled in years; stiff and reluctant as an old man's joints, they shrieked a jagged wound across the silent dark.

Ah. Someone had just picked her front door open.

If her mother ever found out, there'd be no end to the scolding — a girl living alone, and she couldn't even think to prop a chair against the door at night?

Her mother had never quite trusted the world. She checked the gas four or five times before leaving the house, always glanced at the back seat before getting into a car, and never once allowed her daughter to return a stranger's nod or smile.

Mai Minghe had always thought her mother was a little too anxious. She had never imagined that someone would actually break into her home one night.

The sounds that followed were indistinct, but a figure moved through the dimness and stepped inside. Beneath the gap of the door, a beam of light swept back and forth — a flashlight.

Unfamiliar footsteps moved with a muffled tread through the living room, punctuated now and then by a creak. Mai Minghe knew that sound: the wooden floorboards at the kitchen entrance. A pipe had burst there one year, and the boards had warped from the soaking ever since, voicing their sharp complaints at the slightest pressure.

A burglar in the house — now there was something you didn't often see.

She closed her eyes again and listened carefully to what he was doing.

He tried the door of the adjacent room first — a narrow little space that had never really been used for anything. It had been painted a nursery yellow once, then repurposed as a study, then converted into a cloakroom, but none of these identities had ever truly taken hold. By now it was just a junk room, thick with dust.

One look would tell anyone there was nothing in there but heaps of rubbish, not worth a rummage. Sure enough, the footsteps retreated almost immediately, and the door thudded shut.

Honestly, if you searched the whole building together, you'd be hard-pressed to find anything of value.

Things did go missing in this cheap rental block from time to time. Once, Mai Minghe had left her door ajar and come back to find a pair of ankle boots gone from the rack in the entryway — brown calfskin, glossy and sleek, with a smart, trim look. She'd been furious enough to knock on every door in the building asking questions, but nothing came of it. Still, petty pilfering between neighbours was one thing; an actual outside burglar, picking locks and making a production of it, just to rob people who had nothing worth taking — that was something else.

Funny, the small and inconsequential things that stayed with you. She had never found another pair of boots that suited her so well.

Whatever he wanted to take, he was welcome to it. She had nothing worth making a fuss over.

The burglar moved to the bedroom doorway. The door swung open, and the flashlight beam swept in and found Mai Minghe at once.

The harsh white light blazed through her eyelids and lit up her face. She lay perfectly still, eyes shut, feigning sleep.

A strange voice let out an involuntary "Huh?" — as if caught off guard.

Mai Minghe held herself still and said nothing.

The burglar's footsteps padded into the room. He moved in a slow circuit of the bedroom, never even opened the bedside drawer, and then went back out.

He'd never steal anything that way — so careless and half-hearted. She almost felt anxious on his behalf. A person had to have a little patience, had to be willing to see things through properly.

After a minute or two, he came back and approached the bed. The warm, living heat of another person settled over her like a cloud.

"Hey," the man's voice said, and a hand gave Mai Minghe's bony shoulder a nudge. "Hey. Wake up."

It seemed there wasn't much point pretending anymore.

What did he need to wake her for? If he was looking for something worth taking, couldn't he just look for it himself? Not only was he stealing, he was being lazy about it. People these days, honestly.

Mai Minghe opened her eyes. A dark shape crouched over her by the bedside, looming above her head.

The flashlight hung low, aimed at the edge of the mattress, and the burglar's face was swallowed up in shadow. At the margins of the light she could just make out the pale, dim line of his throat, his Adam's apple moving up and down as he spoke.

"Don't be afraid. I just want to ask you something. Is there someone here by the name of Mai Minghe?"

"...That's me. Do we know each other?"

The man drew a breath and straightened up, looking over the shape of her body beneath the covers.

"You — you're the one?" He seemed reluctant to accept it. He raised the flashlight and swept it over Mai Minghe's face several times without the slightest courtesy.

She hadn't looked in a mirror for a long time, and had no idea what she looked like now. Whatever it was, it couldn't be good.

"What is it?" she asked quietly.

The man's mouth hung half open, as though he was still digesting something.

She could tell he was hoping she wasn't Mai Minghe. He asked again almost immediately, enunciating each syllable as if she might have misheard: "Mai — as in the grain. Mai — Ming — He."

"That's me." Mai Minghe gave a small smile. "There's no one else."

The man stared at her.

After a few seconds he asked, "How old are you, ma'am?"

How old was she? Even Mai Minghe had to think about it.

She couldn't say exactly when it had started, but for some years now she'd had trouble keeping track of her own age — sometimes she even mistakenly thought of herself as a young girl.

A year at a time, a year at a time — it didn't sound like much, but the years were like snowflakes, countless and fine; they had piled up, without her noticing, into an entire lifetime.

Scoop up a handful of snow and you won't know when each flake fell. A stretch of her life rises to the surface of her memory, and she can't say how far back it comes from.

The social worker had said that for her age — eighty-six — Mai Minghe's mind was still reasonably clear, not like some of the others—

"Eighty-six?" Mai Minghe addressed the social worker in her memory. "Are you sure? I'm not nearly that old."

The room was quiet again, the soft "whooh — whooh" of the oxygen rising up once more to fill the silence.

The burglar seemed to hear it only now. He pointed at the thin plastic tube in her nose. "Is that... are you on oxygen?"

"Hmm?" She forgot about it sometimes. "Oh — yes. Terribly annoying thing."

The burglar sighed. He set the flashlight down on the edge of the bed, and its circle of light bloomed against the opposite wall, dividing the room — a bright ring of warmth and youth on one side, and the dim, heavy weight of decline beyond it.

"How silly of me — I haven't even asked." Mai Minghe said. "Do you drink tea? It's not often I have a visitor." She had quite forgotten her manners. "Getting up is a bit of a struggle for me, but there's tea and biscuits in the kitchen — help yourself to whatever you like."

The burglar looked uncomfortable, as though this was not at all the scene he had expected.

"No, thank you," he said, then hesitated and added, "But... would you like some? I can bring it to you."

Mai Minghe declined and thanked him. For a little while, homeowner and burglar exchanged polite pleasantries.

The burglar interlaced his fingers and stared at the television in the corner for a long moment, then addressed it: "You're not well?"

"I'm doing quite all right, actually. I can still get out of bed and walk on my own."

"...What about meals? Does a son or daughter bring them to you?"

"I don't have children," she said, with a small smile. "And I don't eat very much these days — a little of anything will do. The social worker brings round vegetables now and then, and eggs."

"A social worker? You have no family in Heimo City?"

"I've grown used to it," said Mai Minghe. "I never had many relatives or friends to speak of, and they all died before me. My dear, would you like to watch some television?"

The burglar seemed to find the question faintly absurd. He fell silent for a moment, then suddenly pulled out his phone, glanced at it, and walked quickly out of the room.

"Hello?"

He'd gone to take a call.

"Yes, I've found her... No, I haven't done it yet." He paused. "Listen — did you know she's an old woman? Eighty-six years old. None of that was in the file."

Whatever the other person said was brief, because the burglar spoke again almost immediately.

"Yes," he said, making no attempt to lower his voice — perhaps he saw no reason to. "But... does it have to be hers? She's not the only one with a gateway. And we don't even know what her gateway is like. If we take it, even a young person would have a hard time surviving that — what if she can't hold on? What if she dies?"

The person on the other end was not pleased. Even Mai Minghe could faintly make out the raised voice through the phone.

The burglar went quiet and bore it for a while. At last, like a student who knows he has done something wrong, he said, "No... I understand. I'm sorry. I'll get it."

Sometimes her own hands startled her.

Thick, furrowed skin draped itself layer upon layer over each slender bone, tendons and veins raised and ridged beneath the surface, barely any warmth left in them at all — a stranger's hands, nothing like the ones she remembered.

She reached with that hand which no longer seemed to belong to her, groping beneath the covers until she found the pendant at her chest, and closed her fist tightly around it.

This time the burglar came straight to the point. "I'm sorry, ma'am. I need to take something from you."

In the dim light she could just make him out — a decent-looking young man, twenty or thirty years old, a boy, really. If no one told you, you'd never guess he was capable of anything like this.

"What is it you want?" asked Mai Minghe. "Oh, I have no use for things anymore — just take whatever you like. There's a silver brooch in the drawer—"

"No, I don't want your belongings," the burglar interrupted. "I need to take something from your body."

"An organ?" she asked, genuinely curious. She couldn't imagine her organs would be worth taking.

"No, no. Don't ask. You wouldn't understand even if I told you."

"Will I... die?" asked Mai Minghe. "You said as much just now."

The burglar was caught off guard. He hesitated for two full seconds before answering. "I don't know... possibly."

Mai Minghe lay quietly for a moment, looking at the crack in the ceiling.

"Then go ahead and take it," she said softly. "Only... before you do, could you grant me one last wish?"

She hadn't noticed when he had come to stand beside her.

"What wish?"

"I used to work at a library. The pay was very small, but I loved it there and I was happy. One day, when my shift was over, one of the librarians told me there was an old book they were clearing out — hadn't sold at the discount sale — and offered to let me take it home."

The burglar's hand came to rest on her pillow.

At his feet there was a dark, squat shape — some kind of machine, she couldn't tell what — that he must have brought in at some point without her noticing. She was only seeing it now.

"I looked at the cover and saw it was a collection of poetry, so I flipped through it at home that evening." Mai Minghe murmured. "I read it, set it down, and then — I don't even know where the book ended up. But somehow, I can't explain it... these past few years, there's been one poem from it that I keep coming back to."

"Which poem?"

"You young people all have one of those... clever phones, don't you?"

"Smartphones," the burglar corrected.

If she'd had grandchildren, perhaps they would have corrected her the same way.

"They say you can find anything on them?"

"...More or less."

"Could you look up that poem for me?" Mai Minghe implored. "I'd like to hear it one more time."

The burglar looked down at her, and something flickered across his face — a sudden awkwardness. He reached over to the bedside table, pulled a tissue from the box, and pressed it into her hand. When Mai Minghe stared at it, bewildered, he said, "It's all right. Don't cry. I'll find it. Do you remember the title?"

She was crying?

So even at this age, she was not ready to die.

Or perhaps at this age, she felt she had never truly had the chance to live.

"It was something about... daisies." Mai Minghe deliberately left out half the title.

Smartphones might hold the whole world inside them, but finding one specific poem was no easy task — and daisies were such a common image in verse. It took a good while, as she'd expected.

After pulling up several poems in a row, none of them right, the burglar finally lost patience. "Ma'am, if you can't remember the name, that's not my fault. I still have to get back and complete my assignment, so you—"

"I've remembered it," said Mai Minghe quickly.

This young man who had come to take something from her — he was probably the last person in her life who could let her hear a poem one more time.

Even if she could delay no longer, even if she had to face death head-on — at least she could listen to one more poem. That was something.

"'I Shall Pick More Daisies'... I think that's the title."

The young man glanced at her, said nothing, and tapped his fingers across the screen a few times.

This time, he found the poem Mei Minghe kept turning over in her mind quickly enough.

"I found you a reading video," he said, setting the phone down on the edge of the bed.

In that still room saturated with the smell of medicine and decay, the ad before the video burst into cheerful noise, announcing a special deal at Little Caesars Pizza.

"The poem starts when the ad's done — just listen. You listen, I'll get to work."

He bent down and pulled a tube from the belly of the dark, squat machine.

...If I had my life to live over,

I would try to make more mistakes.

I would relax.

I would be sillier than I have been this trip.

I would take fewer things seriously.

Mei Minghe felt something warm and wet spreading against her ear.

She had lived like her parents — a lifetime of anxious, grinding care. When wartime inflation hit, she spent every day rationing out their food with painstaking precision; in peacetime, she kept a household ledger every single week. As a child, her family ran a small shop, and no matter how badly she wanted them, she never once dared to steal a piece of candy off the shelf.

As she grew older she came to many crossroads, wild with flowers on either side — and never stepped off the path.

People are strange. Everyone knows they only get one life; yet the way they live each day, it's as if they have all the time in the world, as if there will always be another chance.

The thief lifted her blanket and laid a cool tube against Mei Minghe's chest, and she dimly registered that the thing looked somewhat like an old-fashioned vacuum cleaner.

"What's this?" The thief picked up the pendant resting on her chest, glanced at it, and without waiting for her answer, nudged it aside, away from the mouth of the tube. Young people never recognized it — they had no idea what the thing was for.

Lucky for her that he didn't.

Amid the poem, he pressed the mouth of the tube against Mei Minghe's bony chest. He switched the machine on, and a low hum unlike anything she had ever heard began to spiral slowly through the room.

...If I had my life to live over, I would travel lighter than I have. I would start barefoot earlier in the spring and stay that way later in the fall.

If I could do it again, I would go places and do things and travel lighter than I have.

I would ride more merry-go-rounds,

I would pick more daisies.

I would pick more daisies.

I would pick more daisies.

In the final moment as the darkness of death closed over Mei Minghe, she heard, faintly and half-dissolved, the front door of the house burst open — rushing footsteps, rushing voices, pouring in all at once.

Carried it for years, and finally delivered an ugly child...

"I Shall Pick More Daisies" is a real poem — the poet wrote it when she was eighty-five, just one year older than my daughter. Actually the inspiration didn't come from the poem at all; I'd already started writing when the poem suddenly came back to me, and it felt so perfectly right.

Oh my, it's been so long since I've updated and rambled like this — I feel almost embarrassed. I'm not even sure what to say.

Thank you for coming back.

Chapter 2: Mai Minghe Rescued from Hallucination?

"You live alone,"

The social worker unfolded a small pamphlet and showed it to her, saying: "If you fall and no one knows, it's too dangerous. Best to wear one around your neck — it won't get in your way. What do you think?"

That was several years ago now.

Mai Minghe still remembered the advertisement — the product name was blunt and to the point: "Life Alert."

The image showed a white-haired woman collapsed on the floor, with two lines of small text beneath it: "Help me! I've fallen and I can't get up!"

Her older cousin had shattered her pelvis in her eighties and never got out of bed again; once a person is bedridden, their days are numbered.

What year had she passed? Mai Minghe couldn't remember anymore.

The very legs that had once carried her leaping onto rooftops, running and roughhousing — in the blink of an eye, she now had to be wary of them betraying her even when she simply got up to walk.

The body that had followed her through an entire lifetime had gradually become something foreign; she was like a rusted wheel, each turn slower than the last, powerless to reverse the course.

"The emergency support system runs twenty-four hours a day, three hundred and sixty-five days a year," the social worker explained, afraid she might not be able to read the fine print on the pamphlet. "No matter what kind of emergency, one press and someone will come... let me see, oh — they promise a maximum response time of half an hour, and there are participating hospitals nearby."

Mai Minghe took the pamphlet and studied the pictures for a moment.

She had pinched and scraped and saved all her life, yet now, somehow, money had lost its weight — prices were nothing but curved little symbols.

"I'll take this one," she said, pointing to the third model. "This one is the prettiest. It looks like a pendant."

The social worker let out a small laugh. "Of course — you'll look lovely wearing it."

Though it looked nothing like one, she wore it like a necklace all the same; she had worn it that way for years, right up until the night a burglar walked into her living room to make a phone call — the first time she had ever pressed the Life Alert.

The burglar probably hadn't imagined that the "necklace" on her chest was an alarm — the young and the old live in two worlds almost entirely sealed off from each other; without a regular need to deal with elderly people, few ever learn what life looks like for them, let alone the things they see and use from day to day.

From the moment she had made the burglar search for poems... she had stalled as long as she possibly could, stretching it to over ten minutes.

Still no one had come, and she could barely hold on.

She didn't know why, but the cold metal tube defied gravity — with no one holding it, it stood perfectly upright on her chest. The machine droned on, the recitation of poetry growing fainter and farther away, and she sank into wave after wave of dizzy darkness, deeper and deeper.

From the depths of that darkness, hallucinations surfaced like scattered fragments of a dream.

Strange — they say that at the moment of death, a person sees the memories of their whole life; but what Mai Minghe saw was another version of herself, a tube connected to her chest just the same, walking step by step toward the television, then suddenly lunging forward and crashing into the screen.

She was startled by her own actions, and heard a dull, murky thud somewhere deep in her chest.

With her eyes half-open and half-shut, hallucination and reality overlapped; her hallucinated self hurled against the old television in the corner of the room again and again, and the screen burst into a spiderweb of cracks each time.

The hallucination was finally shattered by a sharp bark — an unfamiliar low, rough voice shouted: "What are you doing? Who are you?"

Mai Minghe jolted, and her eyes cracked open a sliver.

Through her blurred vision, she saw a tube — ink-black and glossy — standing upright on her chest, as though it held more life in it than she did, pressing her heavily into the bed.

The next instant, the tube vanished.

The burglar snatched the tube behind his back and, rattled as he was, kept his wits about him — he turned on the two people who had just burst into the bedroom and demanded: "Who are you? Why are you barging into my grandmother's house?"

Two people strode through the doorway, flicked on the light, and chased away the night; the room blazed white and bright, revealing a bedroom saturated with decay and the smell of medicine, cracks running along the walls, and the steady whoosh-whoosh of an oxygen machine.

They were both wearing blue-and-white uniforms — care workers.

"Your grandmother?"

The male care worker looked at Mai Minghe, then shot a skeptical glance at the burglar. "Her? She's your grandmother?"

"I'm two generations mixed — it doesn't show much." The burglar seemed to register the difference in their complexions and ethnicity; he recovered quickly and said at once: "Look, I have dark hair. Who are you two?"

"We're the emergency response care workers — we came because we received an alert signal, and assumed she had a medical emergency." The other one, a woman, explained. "According to our records, she lives alone."

The burglar had fully composed himself by now.

"Yes," he said, giving Mai Minghe's arm a gentle pat as though to reassure her, then turning to the care workers. "You were very prompt — you got here quickly, thank you both. But there's been a bit of a misunderstanding here. I'm in Heimer City on a work trip and staying with my grandmother for the time being. She's getting on in years, and her mind isn't always clear — she forgot I was coming, so she probably thought I was a stranger and triggered the alarm. She's fine."

The female care worker stepped to the bedside, lifted Mai Minghe's eyelids, checked her over, and asked quietly: "Are you all right, ma'am?"

Mai Minghe opened her mouth, wanting to say something, but only the thinnest thread of breath passed her lips. The female care worker had seen this many times and showed no surprise at her inability to speak; she began listening to her heartbeat.

"Would you mind showing me some identification?" the male care worker asked the burglar, still somewhat uncertain.

"Not at all," the burglar said — and right in front of the care workers, bold as you like, he kicked the black device with its attached tube under Mai Minghe's bed, muttering as he did: "Why is the vacuum cleaner hose lying here... Just a moment, I'll go to the next room to get my wallet. My driver's license is in there."

The bed she lay on was a hospital-style care bed mounted on four wheels, hollow underneath — just the right place to stash something.

"Oh — her phone," the burglar had only taken two steps before he turned back, flashing a smile at the female care worker who was still examining Mai Minghe. "Almost forgot. My grandmother sometimes gets frightened for no reason — you have to play her some poetry or music to settle her down."

The female care worker's gaze drifted over Mai Minghe, lingered on the phone screen for a moment, and something in her expression eased another degree.

Mai Minghe thought: a burglar who breaks in and kills, playing poetry for the homeowner — who would believe that story? If anything, he looked exactly like a devoted grandchild.

Since she wasn't dead yet, the burglar must not have succeeded in taking whatever it was he'd come for from inside her, right?

Right — otherwise he wouldn't still be here playing the dutiful grandson.

Though if the care workers had arrived even a few minutes later, he would have managed it.

No one knew that death had just been sitting beside her, leaning down and gazing at her; she had never been this close to death before, and this was the first time she had ever experienced a dying hallucination...

Right — the television!

Even Mai Minghe herself hadn't expected it — the moment she thought of the hallucination she'd just had, she was suddenly seized by an impulse from nowhere: she wanted to roll out of bed

and go touch the television.

She had to get over there. She had to get over there now...

Wave after wave of urgency crashed through her, and Mai Minghe was so desperate she nearly cried out.

The dark, blank television screen became the only thing in the world that carried any weight, pressing heavily into her field of vision, drawing her toward it; the room, the care workers, and the burglar were like cut-out paper figures, so light they seemed on the verge of floating away.

Mai Minghe strained to raise her hand toward the television.

"What is it, ma'am? What do you need?" The female care worker followed the direction of her raised hand, turned to look, and asked: "Do you want to watch TV?"

The door to the storage room next door opened and closed — just as though the burglar had really gone in to fetch something. He came back right as the female care worker was asking her question, handed his documents to the male care worker; the latter looked them over, and when he spoke again, his whole manner had relaxed.

Mai Minghe let out a sound through her nose — a syllable of negation — but kept her hand pointed at the television.

"I'll turn it on for you," the female care worker said, well-meaning enough, and without waiting for Mai Minghe to answer, switched the television on.

The television was replaying a daytime news commentary program; the host was going over and over the sudden death of Heimer City magnate Wei Xilai the day before, cataloguing his business achievements and philanthropic endeavors.

"No... no." Mai Minghe finally made her voice heard again, which gave her a quiet sense of relief — good, she could speak; her strength was returning.

The burglar shot her a quick glance.

He turned back to the male care worker immediately and picked up where he had left off: "... My grandmother is getting on in years — the more muddled her mind gets, the more stubborn she becomes. There's no family in Heimer City to look after her..."

Such a young person, and already one lie after another.

Telling the care workers he wasn't her grandson would probably accomplish nothing. An ordinary burglar wouldn't stay at the scene to negotiate; from the care workers' point of view, if anything, he looked far less like a burglar than she looked like a senile old woman.

Never mind — the television was more important and more urgent than he was right now.

"Help... help me over there." Mai Minghe pointed at the television and said softly to the female care worker: "Please."

The burglar glanced at her again, then looked at the television set.

Before he could say anything, the male care worker's question hooked away his attention: "When we arrived, you were bent over holding a tube — what were you doing?"

"You don't have to go all the way over there — you can watch television from here." The female care worker seemed a little reluctant.

The burglar was explaining: "My grandmother called out in the middle of the night and woke me up, so I came to check on her, and I found the vacuum cleaner hose had fallen onto the bed."

"Please," Mai Minghe gripped the female care worker's hand tight, fixing her eyes on those brown irises, and pleaded: "Help me over there, please. I... I just want to sit over there for a bit."

She was playing the part of a muddled old woman rather convincingly.

"All right, I'll help you." The female care worker gave in. "Can you get up?"

"Yes, yes."

The burglar glanced at Mai Minghe again and came over of his own accord to help support her — apparently very concerned — which also conveniently extricated him from the male care worker's interrogation. "Grandma, what do you want to go over there for? Have a little look, and then you have to come back to sleep, all right?"

Mai Minghe ignored him. Such a decent-looking young man — what on earth was he doing with himself?

With the two of them supporting her on either side, she shuffled over to the television set in halting steps; her own pale, ghostly half-reflection floated on the screen, then vanished as the broadcast cut to footage of the Wei family estate.

She understood.

So there really had been a reason for the hallucination, Mai Minghe thought.

No wonder she had felt such desperate urgency to come over here — ah, she should have realized sooner; at her age, the mind just wasn't what it used to be.

"I'll get a chair," the female care worker said, letting go of Mai Minghe.

That left only the burglar holding her. He loosely cradled her withered arm, as though he didn't dare grip it too hard.

"If everything's fine, then we'll be on our way." The male care worker stood in the doorway and asked the burglar: "Can you help her back to bed once we're gone?"

The burglar let out a breath of relief. He nodded repeatedly, saying: "Of course — sorry to have put you to all this trouble..."

While he was talking, Mai Minghe suddenly wrenched her arm free, tipped backward, and toppled toward the television screen.

She should have seen it sooner — her hallucination had been telling her exactly how to save herself.

Fall against the television right in front of the care workers, and they would have no choice but to send her to the hospital — no matter what the burglar claimed to be, wasn't that right? And at the hospital, with people all around, she would be safe.

From the corner of her eye she saw the burglar's head snap toward her, but he was a fraction too slow; Mai Minghe heard the heavy, muffled crack of her skull striking the television, and immediately after, gasps and rushing footsteps filled the room.

The female care worker seemed to call out something from somewhere very far away, but Mai Minghe couldn't make out the words —

"Where did she go?"

Posted yesterday

But I didn't expect to start a new book

It's only two chapters — no need to invest so soon, everyone, let's wait and see; what if it gets worse later? Qidian doesn't give refunds on tips, you know.

That goes for all of you too — 95, Qiushui Buran Chen, Xiangsheng Fujin, Wan Jin, Ying You, Xixia You Mu Ming Li, 039 Zhui Nüwa?, Kafka, and everyone else — are you all angel investors or something? I'm overwhelmed with gratitude...

Full disclosure: the book launches on the 12th, and I have to leave town on the 14th... My current chapter stockpile definitely won't survive the turbulence of travel plus bonus chapters from tips — looks like I'll be clacking away on my laptop on the plane again.

P.S.: I've seen some readers asking why this is posted on the men's fiction platform when it's also part of a strong-female-lead special feature. The editors have their reasons — a significant portion of the men's platform readership is actually women who don't visit the women's platform, so a strong-female-lead feature there is meant to draw them in. Think of it as poaching readers for the women's platform's benefit (sort of).